



PARADISE LOST:
In John Milton's 1667 epic poem, Satan commits incest with daughter Sin and their child, Death, rapes his mother

ONE HUNDRED YEARS OF SOLITUDE:
Gabriel García Márquez's 1967 novel shows several cases of sexual intimacy between relatives.

CHINATOWN:
This 1974 Roman Polanski classic has Faye Dunaway giving birth to her own sister after an affair with her father.

THE CEMENT GARDEN: In Ian McEwan's compelling and dark 1978 novel, Jack has a relationship with his elder sister Julie.

THE GOD OF SMALL THINGS:
Arundhati Roy's 1997 novel shows fraternal twins sharing a sexual experience.

Which blood relation have you had sex with?

		Male	Female
Brother	22	12	32
Sister	35	18	52
Mother	4	2	6
Father	4	2	6
None of the above	41	62	28

For 100 of the total of 5,353 respondents who said they had experienced incest. Figures add up to more than 100 because of multiple responses. All figures in per cent.



Of the married women respondents who had experienced an incestuous relationship, 36 per cent had it with their brothers.

the child's silence. These include treats, bribery, coercion, and lies. Given the child's limited experience and understanding, these tactics are often successful for decades of the adult survivor's life.

Where do we draw the line between sexual experimentation and abuse? It is a tricky question, especially with sibling incest. Although some writers use an age difference of three years or the legal definition of majority, the answer is not that simple. Sexual abuse is not simply a matter of age, size, and strength, but disparity of power.

In the 2008 INDIA TODAY-AC Nielsen-ORG MARG SEX survey, the largest number of respondents who have had sex with blood relatives indicate it was with a sibling. While sibling incest might be the most frequent type, it is also possible that it's considered less shameful than parent-child sexual activity, and, therefore, is more likely to be disclosed.

Given the factors that keep people silent, we may never know the true incidence of incest. Statistics generally accepted by researchers and clinicians indicate that one-third to half of girls and one-eighth to one-sixth of boys are sexually abused by the age of 18. Most professionals think these estimates are very conservative, and the actual numbers are much higher.

Is incestuous activity always harmful? I doubt that we can answer this question. It is possible that some children who experience incest move on easily from the experience, suffering no long-lasting ill effects. It is not unusual for incest survivors to struggle in isolation for decades before disclosing to anyone, and seeking help and support. Before they begin their recovery they are likely to engage in strategies to avoid, hide, distract from, or numb their pain. These can include

excessive use of alcohol and other drugs, food, sex, work, exercise, religion, use of pornography, compulsive care giving, and many more. When first discovered by the child victim or adult survivor, these survival strategies work to reduce the pain. Over the time, however, its effectiveness diminishes and the survivor resorts to more of this "medication". Ultimately, the survival strategy becomes an addiction or compulsion.

The incest survivor is not wrong to have adopted these survival strategies. These are the best he or she could do at the time. A child victim, possessing limited size, strength, understanding and resources, has only one task: to get through the experience in any possible way until he or she has developed enough safety and resources to begin healing.

Recovery from the hurts of incest and other sexual abuse can be a long and often painful process, but the results justify the effort. The survivor's life improves. Relationships become healthier, life more integrated, and there are even times of joy.

There are many resources available to survivors worldwide: books, support organisations, online forums, websites, groups, workshops, counsellors, and therapists. There is no need to continue suffering in silence and isolation.

The writer is a US-based psychotherapist and author of the book Victims No Longer: The Classic Guide for Men Recovering from Sexual Child Abuse.

For past surveys, interactive graphics visit:
www.indiatoday.in/sexsurvey08

